of large numbers of people within a very short space of time, the novelty of Ashoka's innovation may not be immediately obvious. What has to be kept in mind is that in ancient India, where the technology for multiple reproduction did not exist, the state could not reach out and express its desires and directives in the way it does now. So, the emperor's decision to get multiple copies of his message prepared and sent to various provinces was an attempt at text-based mass communication, a kind of force multiplier which ensured that the message had a massive reach. Usually, when we think of culture in ancient India as text-created, formalized religious iconography comes to mind—images that depict textual narratives. Here, by contrast, a ruler attempts to create an image of himself via the words of his message, his attempt being to convey the *same* image of himself in every part of his empire. In this reaching out it was of special importance to him that his subjects hear the singularity and sameness of his voice across the land that he ruled.

The messages will have been composed on the orders of the emperor, at points in time when he was possibly on tour, first written out on materials which have since perished. They were then dispatched to various administrative centres. In each instance, it was likely that the message was sent to a prince who was the viceroy of the province and who, in turn, readdressed it and conveyed it to officials in his territory for onward dissemination. We know this because in one instance, where three versions of an edict are found within a few kilometres of each other, the subsidiary instructions and greetings from the provincial head have also been inscribed. These three form a cluster in the Chitradurga district of Karnataka, at Brahmagiri, Siddapura, and Jatinga-Rameshwara.[12] All of them note that the prince, described as 'aryaputra'—a designation suggesting that the man addressed was Ashoka's own son—and officials, called mahamatras, from Suvarnagiri (the capital of the southern province of the empire) wished the mahamatras at Isila good health. After this initial